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exa-PD: A scalable high-performance workflow for multi-element phase diagram construction

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DOI: 10.xxxxxx/draft

Software

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Editor:

Submitted: 24 September 2026
Published: unpublished

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Summary

exa-PD is a highly parallelizable workflow designed for the construction of multi-element phase diagrams (PDs). It uses standard sampling techniques—molecular dynamics (MD) and Monte Carlo (MC)—as implemented in the LAMMPS package (Thompson et al., 2022), to simultaneously sample multiple phases over a fine temperature–composition mesh for free-energy calculations. Parsl (Babuji et al., 2019) serves as the global workflow engine, coordinating large ensembles of MD and MC tasks to achieve massive parallelization with strong scalability. The resulting free energies of liquid and solid phases are then fed to CALculation of PHAse Diagrams (CALPHAD) modeling via the PyCalphad package (Otis & Liu, 2017) to construct multi-element PDs, as illustrated in Figure 1.

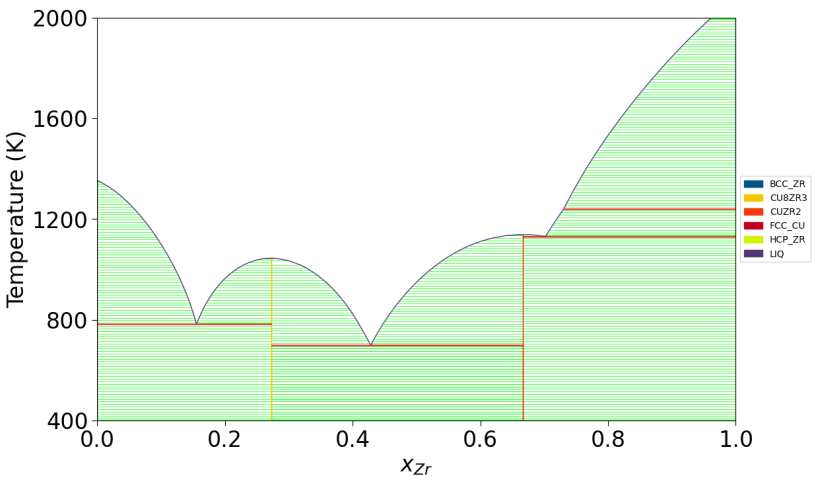


Figure 1: Phase diagram of the Cu–Zr system predicted by exa-PD using an EAM-FS potential.

By leveraging Parsl, a parallel programming library for Python, exa-PD enables scalable execution of large ensembles of MD and MC simulations with internal task dependencies across heterogeneous resources. The framework supports efficient scaling from a single workstation to multi-node supercomputers and exhibits near-linear scaling up to 32 GPU nodes and 32 CPU nodes through dynamic task distribution, as shown by the benchmark results in Ref. (Zhang et al., 2026) and in Figure 3 of this work.

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Statement of need

Computational materials discovery has progressed rapidly with advances in computing and AI/ML techniques. However, experimental validation remains limited, largely due to insufficient knowledge of viable synthesis pathways. Reliable multi-element phase diagrams are therefore essential for resolving thermodynamic phase competition under synthesis conditions and for predicting synthesizability. Constructing these phase diagrams computationally requires highly accurate free-energy calculations. The exa-PD workflow is intended for computational materials researchers who need to construct phase diagrams from atomistic simulations, particularly when large numbers of free-energy calculations must be performed across phases, compositions, and temperatures.

State of the field

Existing tools address complementary parts of this problem. LAMMPS provides the underlying atomistic simulations, while automated free-energy frameworks such as CALPHY focus primarily on individual free-energy calculations and thermodynamic integration paths (Menon et al., 2021). PyCalphad (Otis & Liu, 2017), in turn, performs thermodynamic modeling once the required free-energy descriptions are available. exa-PD provides the scalable workflow needed to connect these capabilities by coordinating large ensembles of dependent MD/MC calculations across phases, temperatures, and compositions and transforming their outputs into a thermodynamic database suitable for CALPHAD modeling.

Rather than reimplementing established simulation or CALPHAD functionality, exa-PD builds on LAMMPS and PyCalphad and provides the domain-specific orchestration, dependency management, heterogeneous resource allocation, and postprocessing required for scalable phase-diagram construction. The implementation of a global controller using Parsl ensures massive parallelization with strong scalability, efficiently managing MD/MC jobs to handle resource-intensive calculations. By abstracting task execution into a flexible dependency graph, Parsl enables a data-driven execution model in which tasks are triggered as soon as their required inputs become available. While many MD tasks leverage GPU acceleration, certain essential features remain restricted to CPU execution, making heterogeneous CPU/GPU resources necessary. Parsl accommodates such heterogeneous execution across multiple node types, thereby enabling high-throughput management of MD simulations for free-energy calculations.

Software design

exa-PD adopts a task-based workflow architecture rather than a monolithic parallel executable because phase-diagram construction consists of many computationally expensive but largely independent MD/MC calculations connected by a relatively small number of data dependencies. Figure 2 gives a schematic flowchart of the exa-PD workflow, outlining the required and optional MD/MC jobs for constructing a phase diagram, with the internal dependencies among the MD/MC jobs indicated by orange arrows. In principle, one needs the absolute free energy of solid and liquid phases to generate a phase diagram. The absolute free energy can be obtained by using a reference system, of which the free energy can be analytically derived, and calculating the free energy difference between the target and reference systems with a thermodynamic integration (TI).

The first module of the workflow calculates the free energy of solid phases (line compounds) by using a reference system such as an Einstein crystal at a certain temperature and estimating the Frankel-Ladd TI. Then it ramps up or ramps down the temperature to obtain the free energies at other temparatures by integrating the Gibbs-Helmholtz equation. The second module calculates the free energy of liquids. Taking a binary system $A_{1-x}B_x$ as an example, the free energy of pure liquid A is first obtained using the Uhlenbeck-Ford model (UFM) as the

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reference system, then the alchemical TI is used to obtain the free energy of other compositions $A_{1-x}B_x$. The third module is optional and determines the melting temperature of a certain solid phase using the solid-liquid coexistence (SLC) technique. SLC simulations are helpful to validate the free energy results. For example, the agreement of the melting temperature of a solid phase derived from the SLC simulations and from the solid/liquid free energy calculations confirms the reliability of both methods.

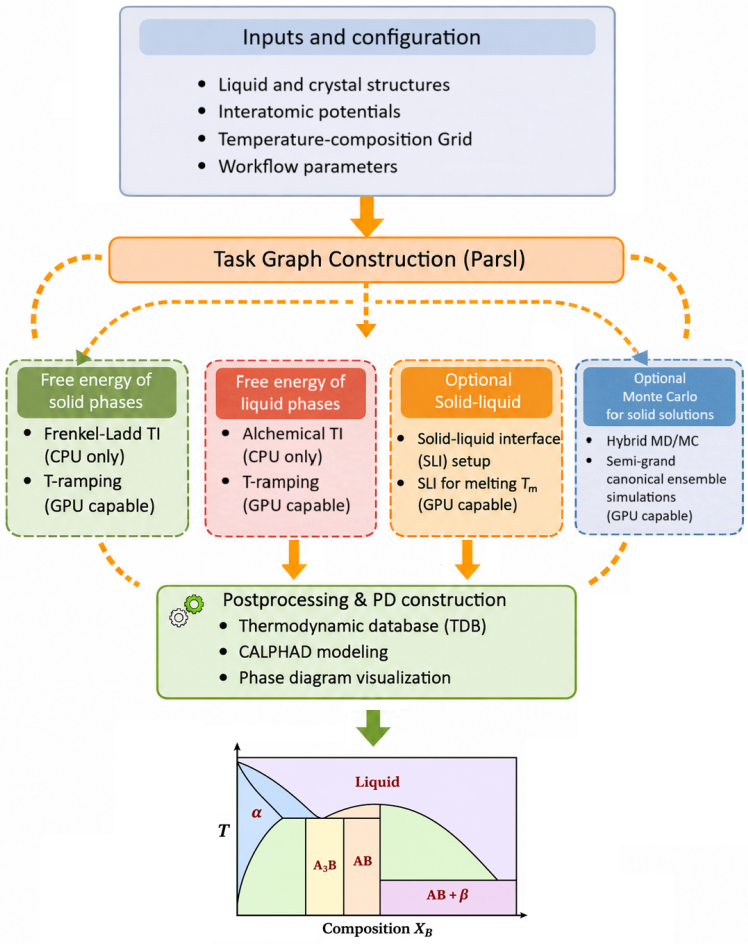


Figure 2: Schematic flowchart of the exa-PD workflow.

The execution model of exa-PD relies on Parsl's dynamic task distribution. Each module includes multiple asynchronous tasks that Parsl distributes across available computing resources. While many MD tasks benefit from GPU acceleration, some essential calculations are currently limited to CPU execution. For example, Frankel–Ladd and alchemical TI calculations rely on LAMMPS features that are not supported by existing GPU or KOKKOS backends. However, when using the pre-compiled LAMMPS executable in the DeepMD package to implement the DeepMD neural network potentials (NNP), all calculations presented in Figure 2 can be executed efficiently on GPUs, enabling flexible utilization of heterogeneous CPU and GPU resources.

In addition, exa-PD leverages Parsl to manage the dependency structure among hundreds of MD tasks. For example, the solid phase must first be equilibrated to determine the equilibrium volume and mean square displacement (MSD) for each species, in order to initialize the Frankel–Ladd TI. Such task dependencies are expressed and enforced by the Parsl controller

through its futures-based execution model.

After completion of all MD tasks, the results are postprocessed using the `run_process.py` script. For each solid phase, the script generates a two-column dataset of Gibbs free energy G as a function of temperature T. For the liquid phase, it produces a multi-column dataset of $G(T, x)$, with each column corresponding to a distinct composition. The postprocessing step also generates a thermodynamic database in TDB format that includes entries for all computed solid and liquid phases. Additionally, a sample script, `plot_PD.py`, is provided to visualize the Cu–Zr phase diagram as shown in Figure 1 using the PyCalphad package based on the generated TDB file.

Solid structures can be supplied in commonly used Crystallographic Information File (CIF), Vienna *ab initio* Simulation Package (VASP) (Kresse & Furthmüller, 1996) POSCAR, or LAMMPS formats. This allows exa-PD to interface with existing atomistic-simulation workflows.

Research impact statement

exa-PD has been applied to the construction of the Cu–Zr phase diagram using atomistic free-energy calculations, providing an end-to-end demonstration from MD simulations to a CALPHAD thermodynamic description. Figure 3 summarizes the strong scaling results for the Cu-Zr system, evaluated on both GPU and CPU nodes. The benchmark tests are performed on Perlmutter at the National Energy Research Scientific Computing Center (NERSC). The execution time is plotted as a function of the number of compute nodes, along with the ideal linear scaling behavior (dashed lines) for reference. Both GPU and CPU results closely follow the ideal scaling trend up to 32 nodes, achieving parallel efficiencies of ~89% and ~90%, respectively. These results demonstrate that the workflow can exploit large-scale high-performance computing (HPC) resources for phase-diagram calculations that require hundreds of coordinated atomistic simulations. The methodology and its application have also been reported in Ref. (Zhang et al., 2026), demonstrating the software in a reproducible research application.

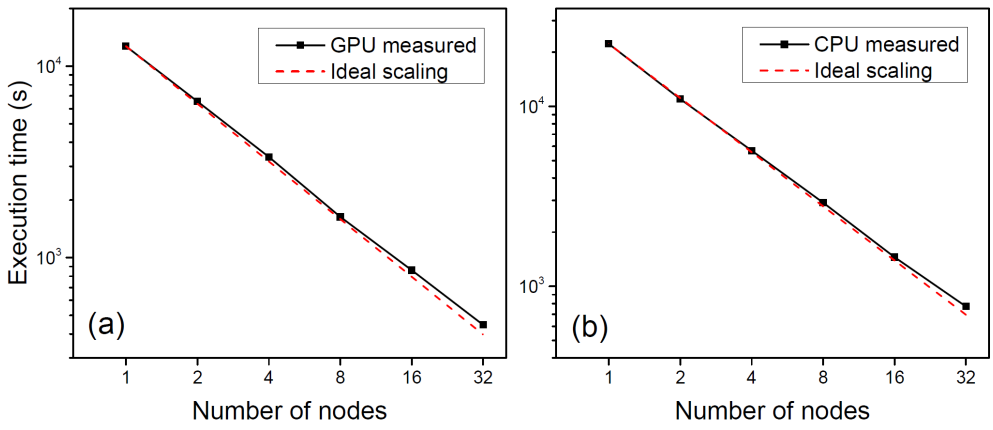


Figure 3: Strong scaling of exa-PD workflow on NERSC's Perlmutter supercomputer. Wall-clock times are shown for both GPU and CPU nodes.

AI usage disclosure

OpenAI ChatGPT (GPT-5.6 and earlier ChatGPT models) was used to assist with language polishing, manuscript organization, figure layouts refinement and documentation generation.

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All AI-assisted documentation, manuscript text and figures were reviewed and verified by the authors for technical accuracy.

Acknowledgements

This work was supported by the U.S. Department of Energy (DOE), Office of Science, Basic Energy Sciences, Materials Science and Engineering Division through the Computational Material Science Center program. Ames National Laboratory is operated for the U.S. DOE by Iowa State University under contract # DE-AC02-07CH11358. Los Alamos National Laboratory is operated by Triad National Security, LLC, for the National Nuclear Security Administration of U.S. Department of Energy under Contract No. 89233218CNA000001.

This research used resources provided by the National Energy Research Scientific Computing Center, supported by the Office of Science of the U.S. Department of Energy under Contract No. DE-AC02-05CH11231, and resources provided by the Los Alamos National Laboratory Institutional Computing Program.

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